For this to work, the router must detect when two messages are similar. This is done by the hash created from each message's string. There are several steps to assigning a message to a routee, as shown in figure 6.7. (These are Akka internals that are not visible to normal users.)

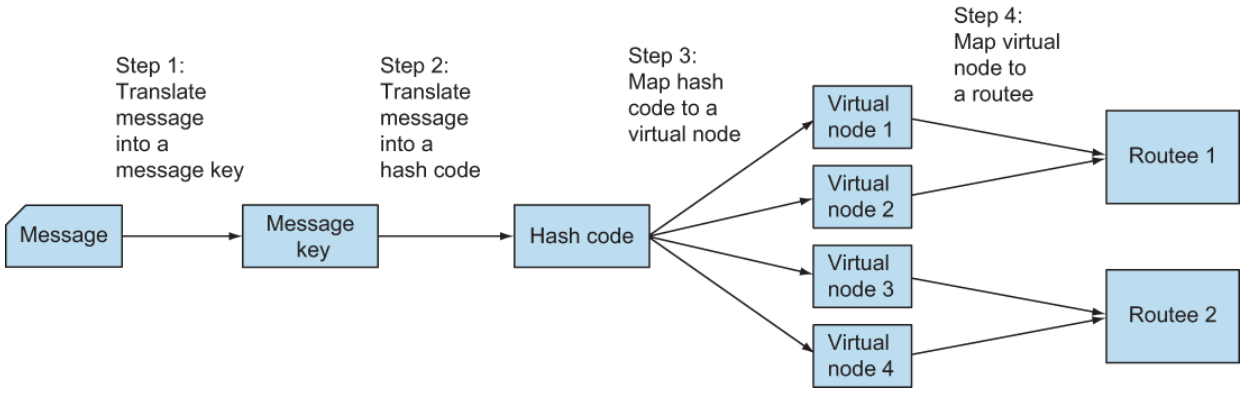


Figure 6.7 Steps the consistent hashing router follows to decide which routee to select

In step 1, the message is translated into the message key of type `String`. Similar joinable messages have the same key: for example, the message ID. It does not matter how this key is constructed; the only restriction is that the key is always the same for similar messages. The extraction of this message key is different for each type of message and must be implemented. Therefore, a router with the constant hashing strategy requires the definition of this mapping function.

In step 2, a hash code is created from this message key. This hash code is used to select a virtual node (step 3). Step 4 is to select the routee that handles all messages for this virtual node.